

Types of Comprehension Questions

I Give two/three reasons/results/factors ...

Examples

Give three reasons why Mr Armroyd had suspected that there was something wrong with Luther's way of living.

What is your answer? Can you answer without referring back to the passage?

Give three problems which Paul Brown faced in his attempt to track down the Sierra and obtain evidence against it.

What is your answer?

2 Questions about the effects of words in the passage

Example 1

During supper, George's face was stony but by the time the meal was through he observed that his wife's was stonier.

- Q. What do the words 'stony' and 'stonier' tell us about how George and his wife looked?

What is your answer?

Example 2

Stories about an undercover whaling ship going 'cowboy-hunting' had been circulating for some time. 'Greenpeace', the anti-whaling and conservation group, had even named her last year.

- Q. Why does the author use 'even' here?

Can you explain the author's purpose in using this word?

3 Questions which force you to search for particular words in the passage

Example 1

Feeling somewhat ashamed of what he had done, Luther stared at the floor and carefully avoided looking at his mother or at Mr Armroyd. Mrs Brimlow was shrewd enough to guess which way the wind was blowing. She began to adopt a more conciliatory tone.

- Q. Quote the single word in the passage which best shows that each of these statements is true:
- (i) Luther did not feel proud of himself at that time.
 - (ii) When Mrs Brimlow began to speak again, she was much more reasonable in her attitude.

What are the words?

Example 2

Paul Brown showed initiative and persistence in his attempt to track down the Sierra and demonstrate to the public what was going on. Not content with merely tracing the ship, he contrived to get photographic evidence which would attract publicity and could not be denied.

- Q. Quote the single word in the passage which best suggests that Paul Brown was not the sort of man who gives up easily.

4 Questions asking about how a person (place or thing) changes during a passage

Example 1

What change, if any, occurred in Mr Armroyd's attitude in the passage (about Luther)?

Example 2

How did Paul Brown's attitude to his task probably change during the period of time covered in the passage?

What are your answers? These are challenging questions. Don't give up. Work out the answers.

5 True/false questions

Example

Do the following sentences accurately describe the character of Paul Brown as shown in the passage about the *Sierra*? Answer **Yes** or **No** for each sentence.

- a) He probably supported the aims of the 'Greenpeace' group.
- b) He was a resourceful man.
- c) He was envious of the success of the *Sierra*.
- d) He was unconcerned about the fate of whales.

Are these sentences right or wrong?

6 Questions which test your understanding of a situation and of its likely consequences

These may be questions about what somebody might have said or about what might have happened after an incident.

Example 1

Write down **two** statements which the captain of the *Sierra* might have said to his crew after Brown was first seen taking photographs of the ship.

Make up two possible statements.

Example 2

When Armroyd returned home, his wife asked him if he had had a good day at work. Write down **two** statements in reply to this question. In the first statement let Armroyd say where he had been. In the second statement let him say what he thought of his visit to the Brimlows' home.

Make up two statements which Armroyd might have made to his wife.

7 Questions which involve some knowledge of grammatical terms

In a few questions, you may need to know what a verb, adjective, phrase or clause is. These questions are not common but they have occurred in the past. These are typical examples. Do not try to find the answers because you do not know which passage they refer to.

- a) Write down **three** verbs from the second paragraph which give the impression that inanimate (or lifeless) objects were actively on the young men's side.
- b) Quote an adjectival phrase of five words from the third paragraph.

Please see Units 63 and 64, which deal with the grammatical knowledge you are expected to have.

8 Questions which deal with punctuation marks, the use of italics and other technical points

These questions are not common but they occur sometimes.

Example 1

In line 15, why is 'dead' in inverted commas?

Example 2

In line 74, why is FRESH in capital letters?

Example 3

In line 8, why is *poaching* in italics?

Example 4

How would the final sentence of the second paragraph be changed in meaning if we left out the comma after 'men'?

9 Questions about the author of a passage

These questions may deal with an author's aim, his attitude to his topic or to his tone.

Example 1

What seems to be the main aim of the author in writing this passage about locusts?

Example 2

As far as we can tell, what is the author's attitude to Paul Brown?

Example 3

The tone of this passage is (ironical, sarcastic, objective, humorous, cynical). Which of the five words is most appropriate here?

10 Questions about the main point of a passage or paragraph

11 Questions asking what a pronoun or other word refers to

Example

At first Brown was uncertain whether information from Lloyd's about the movement of the *Sierra* was reliable, but he soon discovered that it was indeed, and this made his task less difficult.

Q. What does *it* refer to in line 2?

What is the answer?

12 Inferences and implications

Example 1

A university course for a first degree normally lasts three years.

Q. What does the writer imply by using 'normally'?

A. He implies that some courses may be longer or shorter than three years.

Q. What may we infer from the writer's use of 'normally' in this sentence?

A. (We may infer that) sometimes a university course lasts for less or more than three years.

Notice that the writer **implies** but the reader **infers**.

Example 2

The number of deaths and serious injuries as a result of traffic accidents has increased steadily in the past twenty years. Unfortunately, there is no sign that this increase will be checked or that the number of accidents will begin to fall.

Q. What may we infer about the writer's attitude to road safety from his use of 'unfortunately'?

A. (We may infer that) he thinks that more action is needed to reduce the number of accidents.

Q. What does the writer imply by using 'unfortunately' in this passage?

A. (He implies that) something should be done to reduce the number of accidents.

Example 3

Although living standards continue to rise throughout the world, there are large areas where unfortunate peasants are forced to struggle hard merely to find food for their families. In too many cases, failure to obtain food has led to malnutrition and death.

Q. 1 What may we infer about the writer's attitude by his use of 'unfortunate' in line 2?

Q. 2 What does the writer imply by using 'too many' in line 3?